

his affair with the novelist Aurore Dudevant (1804–1876), better known by her pen name George Sand. When she met Chopin in 1836, she was already famous because of her writings and unconventional life: separated from her husband, with two children, she had numerous lovers, wore men's clothing, and smoked cigars. Her affair with Chopin began in earnest in 1838 and they spent the winter of 1838–1839 together on the island of Majorca.

The relationship lasted almost a decade before ending acrimoniously in 1847. By this time Chopin's health was in decline, he was short of money, and Paris was an uncomfortable place to be, with revolution in the air after King Louis Philippe was deposed in February 1848. Chopin escaped by staying in England and Scotland from April to November. He gave public concerts in London, Manchester, Edinburgh, and Glasgow, but mainly performed in aristocratic homes—in London (where Queen Victoria was guest of honor on one occasion) and in Scotland (in country houses belonging to friends and relatives of his Scottish pupil Jane Stirling; see [box](#)). By now he was so ill that he looked like a walking corpse. He could no longer climb stairs and had to be carried up by his servant, but he could still produce magic at the piano.